

Schools chief put on leave after FBI searches

L.A. Unified names acting superintendent as feds vet Carvalho, who isn't charged.

By HOWARD BLUME

Los Angeles schools Supt. Alberto Carvalho has been placed on indefinite administrative leave, officials announced Friday — two days after FBI agents raided his home and office related to an undisclosed criminal investigation.

Andres Chait, a senior LAUSD administrator who has served as chief of school operations, was named acting superintendent, an announcement made by board President Scott Schmerelson.

"I know that this is a very challenging time," Schmerelson said, "and I want you to know that the Board believes in you, supports you and know that you will all continue to do your very best to support the students and families of the district."

It was not clear whether Schmerelson was addressing Carvalho, the community or both. After his remarks, board members quickly exited the room in silence.

The FBI has not accused Carvalho of wrongdoing, but sources told The Times that Carvalho is a target of an investigation into AllHere, a defunct company that designed an all-purpose chatbot for the nation's second-largest school system.

In a statement, the district said the action was taken to show "leadership remains focused on the mission of providing world-class teaching and learning in the classroom. While we understand the need for information, we cannot discuss the specifics of this matter pending investigation."

The district also released a statement from Chait, who said: "Our focus remains clear: to ensure stability, continuity, and strong leadership for our students, families, and employees."

The chatbot was unveiled in March 2024 and quietly withdrawn from limited [See Carvalho, A9]



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ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

PARAMOUNT Skydance Chairman David Ellison walks to the State of the Union address at the Capitol on Tuesday, top. Above, Warner Bros. Studios in Burbank.

Trump orders U.S. agencies to stop using Anthropic AI

Move escalates fight over use in defense technology

By QUEENIE WONG

President Trump on Friday directed federal agencies to stop using technology from San Francisco artificial-intelligence company Anthropic, escalating a high-profile clash between the AI startup and the Pentagon over safety.

In a Friday post on the social media site Truth Social, Trump described the company as "radical left" and "woke."

"We don't need it, we don't want it, and will not do business with them again!" Trump said.

The president's harsh words mark a major escalation in the ongoing battle be-

tween some in the Trump administration and several technology companies over the use of artificial intelligence in defense tech.

Anthropic has been sparing with the Pentagon, which had threatened to end its \$200-million contract with the company on Friday if it didn't loosen restrictions on its AI model so it could be used for more military purposes. Anthropic had been asking for more guarantees that its tech wouldn't be used for surveillance of Americans or autonomous weapons.

The tussle could hobble Anthropic's business with the government. The Trump administration said the company was added to a

sweeping national security blacklist, ordering federal agencies to immediately discontinue use of its products and barring any government contractors from maintaining ties with it.

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, who met with Anthropic's Chief Executive Dario Amodei this week, criticized the tech company after Trump's Truth Social post.

"Anthropic delivered a master class in arrogance and betrayal as well as a textbook case of how not to do business with the United States Government or the Pentagon," he wrote Friday on social media site X.

Anthropic didn't im- [See Anthropic, A11]

Paramount's 3-part plot to win Warner Bros.

The Ellison family relied on lobbying, a lawsuit and a lot of money to top Netflix in battle.

By MEG JAMES

The morning after Netflix clinched its deal to buy Warner Bros., Paramount Skydance Chairman David Ellison assembled a war room of trusted advisors, including his billionaire father, Larry Ellison.

Furious at Warner Bros. Discovery Chief David Zaslav for ending the auction, the Ellison family and their team began plotting their comeback on that crisp December day.

To rattle Warner Bros. Discovery and its investors, they launched a three-front campaign: a lawsuit, a hostile takeover bid and direct lobbying of the Trump administration and Republicans in Congress.

"There was a master battle plan — and it was extremely disciplined," said one auction insider who was not authorized to comment publicly.

Netflix stunned the industry late Thursday by pulling out of the bidding, clearing the way for Paramount to claim the company that owns HBO, HBO Max, CNN, TBS, Food Network and the Warner Bros.

film and television studios in Burbank. The deal was valued at more than \$111 billion.

The streaming giant's reversal came just hours after co-Chief Executive Ted Sarandos met with Atty Gen. Pam Bondi and a deputy at the White House. It was a cordial session, but the Trump officials told Sarandos that his deal was facing significant hurdles in Washington, according to a person close to the administration who was not authorized to comment publicly.

Even before that meeting, the tide had turned for Paramount in a swell of power, politics and brinkmanship.

"Netflix played their cards well, however, Paramount played their cards perfectly," said Jonathan Miller, chief executive of Integrated Media Company. "They did exactly what they had to do and when they had to do it — which was at the very last moment."

Key to victory was Larry Ellison, his vast \$200-billion fortune and his connections to Trump and congressional Republicans.

Paramount also hired Trump's former antitrust chief, attorney Makan Delrahim, to quarterback the firm's legal and regulatory action.

Republicans during a Senate hearing this month piled onto Sarandos with [See Paramount, A12]

What could deal mean for CNN?

Paramount-Warner Bros. pact stirs fears about the future of the cable news channel.

By SAMANTHA MASUNAGA

As the media industry took stock of Paramount Skydance's startling acquisition of Warner Bros. Discovery, one question lingered on the minds of many in the news business and beyond: What will this mean for CNN?

The iconic 24-hour cable news network is among the various Warner Bros. assets that would be scooped up by Paramount in a deal announced Thursday that could transform the media landscape.

Paramount has undergone a swift transformation under Chief Executive David Ellison following his family's acquisition of the company last summer.

These changes reached CBS News almost immediately with the appointment of Bari Weiss, the controversial Free Press co-founder,

as its new editor in chief.

Weiss' tenure has been rocky. Her decision to pull a "60 Minutes" story about conditions inside an El Salvador prison that housed undocumented Venezuelan migrants from the U.S. received criticism and accusations of political motivation. The network said the story was held for more reporting, and the segment aired.

There was more upheaval last week at the news magazine, when "60 Minutes" correspondent and CNN news anchor Anderson Cooper announced that he'd be leaving to spend more time with his family.

And earlier this year, a veteran producer at "CBS Evening News With Tony Dokoupil" was fired after he expressed disagreement about the editorial direction of the newscast.

Now, the concern is that similar changes could be in store for CNN, which has long been a target of President Trump's ire. He has personally called for the ouster of hosts at the network who have questioned his policies. [See CNN, A12]



ROBIN LITTLE Redferns via Getty Images

OLDIES BUT GOODIES

Singer-songwriter Neil Sedaka's contributions to the canon include "Breaking Up Is Hard to Do."

NEIL SEDAKA, 1939 – 2026

His pop melodies topped the charts

By STEPHEN THOMAS ERLEWINE

Neil Sedaka, an irrepressible songsmith who parlayed his compositional skills into pop stardom during the height of the Brill Building era in the 1960s and later staged an easy-listening comeback in the 1970s, has died at age 86. No cause of death was immediately available.

"Our family is devastated by the sudden passing of our beloved husband, father and grandfather, Neil Sedaka," the songwriter's family wrote in a statement to The Times. "A true rock and roll legend, an inspiration to millions, but most importantly, at least to those of us who were lucky enough to know him, an incredible human being who will be deeply missed."

A chipper melodist who never attempted to disguise his sentimental streak, Sedaka emerged at the moment rock 'n' roll's initial big bang [See Sedaka, A6]

Clinton testimony suggests precedent

Ex-president faces House questions on Epstein, fueling calls for Trump to do same.

By STEPHEN GROVES

WASHINGTON — Former President Clinton told members of Congress on Friday that he "did nothing wrong" in his relationship with Jeffrey Epstein and saw no signs of Epstein's sexual abuse as he faced hours of grilling from lawmakers over his connections to the disgraced financier from more than two decades ago.

"I saw nothing, and I did nothing," the Democratic former president said in an opening statement he shared on social media at the outset of the deposition. The closed-door deposition ended after more than six hours of questioning from lawmakers who said he answered every question posed to him.

The deposition in Chappaqua, N.Y., marked the first time a former president has been compelled to testify to Congress. It came a day after Clinton's wife, former Secretary of State Hillary Clinton, sat with lawmakers for her own deposition.

Democrats, who have

supported the push to get answers from Bill Clinton, are arguing that it sets a precedent that should also apply to President Trump, a Republican who had his own relationship with Epstein.

"I think that President Trump needs to man up, get in front of this committee and answer the questions and stop calling this investigation a hoax," said Rep. Robert Garcia of Long Beach, the top Democrat on the committee, on Friday.

Republican Rep. James Comer, the chair of the House Oversight Committee, has pushed back on that idea, saying that Trump has answered questions on Epstein from the press.

Bill Clinton has also not been accused of any wrongdoing. Yet lawmakers are grappling with what accountability in the United States looks like at a time when men around the world have been toppled from their high-powered posts for maintaining their connections with Epstein after he pleaded guilty in 2008 to state charges in Florida for soliciting prostitution from an underage girl.

"Men — and women for that matter — of great power and great wealth from all [See Clinton, A7]

Possible successors to 'El Mencho'

With the cartel leader dead, his commanders may share power, pick a leader or fight. **WORLD, A2**

Sinaloa cartel leaders charged

Indictment is the latest to bring narco-terrorism charges against violent organizations' leaders. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Child predator is rearrested

D.A. files new charges against David Allen Funston after backlash over release on elderly parole. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Very warm.
L.A. Basin: 86/57. **B8**

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ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times
DAVE ROBERTS' team off to a hot start.

Dodgers look for an edge in spring

Manager Dave Roberts knows "playing your best baseball at the right time" is key, Bill Shaikin writes. **SPORTS, B12**

Markets

..... **A11**
Opinion Voices **A13**